

The failure modes, as a checklist

25 patterns and 102 things to check, in the order the guide introduces them.

Each line is something you can observe rather than something you have to judge – so tick it only if it is true now, not if it once was or might be.

A single tick under a pattern means little. Several under the same one means that pattern is worth reading in full, and the guide has a page for each.

DOING THIS AS A GROUP

Hand everyone their own copy and let them tick it privately first, so the room does not anchor on the loudest voice. The RCOS facilitation guide turns that into a 60–90 minute session that ends with a named owner and a date.

rcos.ecohubs.community/articles/rcos-stress-tests/facilitation-worksheet

Filled in by

Date

POWER NOBODY VOTED FOR

01 Authority that comes from being compelling L2

- ☐ Disagreement gets reframed as something the disagreeing person needs to work on.
- ☐ Their view is described as insight, and other people's as opinion.
- ☐ Newcomers adopt their framing unusually fast, including its vocabulary.
- ☐ There is no forum where their contribution is treated as one contribution.

02 Decisions with no stated type L2

- ☐ Arguments about whether something needs the whole group start before the discussion does.
- ☐ The same kind of decision has gone two different routes in the last year.
- ☐ Somebody can end a debate by saying "that's just operational".
- ☐ Nobody can say which decisions require a higher bar without checking with a person.

03 Speakers who fill the room L2

- ☐ The same two or three people speak first on almost every item.
- ☐ Proposals from quieter members arrive under-developed, and are judged for it.
- ☐ Meetings run long and the last agenda items are always decided fastest.
- ☐ Somebody who stopped contributing cannot say when or why they stopped.

04 The clique that decides before the meeting L2

- ☐ Proposals arrive at the meeting already resolved, and discussion feels ceremonial.
- ☐ Some members are surprised by context others clearly had beforehand.
- ☐ Attendance is falling among people who have not stopped caring.
- ☐ The same three or four names appear in every account of "how that was decided".
- ☐ New members take an unusually long time to work out how anything happens.

- 05 **The founder's informal veto** L2
- ☐ Proposals get quietly checked with one person before they reach a meeting.
 - ☐ Their objection ends a discussion, and nobody asks which rule it came under.
 - ☐ Members describe ideas as "not worth raising", without being able to say why.
 - ☐ The agreements say nothing about them having any special standing.
 - ☐ When they are away, decisions wait rather than proceed.

CONFLICT THAT NEVER RESOLVES

- 06 **Conflict that is never named** L4
- ☐ Difficulties are discussed widely in private and never once in a meeting.
 - ☐ Departures surprise nobody, and the reasons were never said out loud.
 - ☐ The conflict process exists and has not been used in years.
 - ☐ Somebody is described as "just like that", and the group works around them.
- 07 **Punishment before repair** L4
- ☐ The first available response to a breach is a sanction, with nothing cheaper below it.
 - ☐ Consequences are decided in the same conversation that hears the complaint.
 - ☐ Members raise things only once they are already unrecoverable.
 - ☐ Sanctions have no stated end date, and nobody can say what restores standing.

WHERE THE MONEY QUIETLY MOVES

- 08 **Contribution that stops being shared** L3
- ☐ Members may buy out of work hours, and the rate was never really calculated.
 - ☐ The people doing the physical work and the people with money are becoming different groups.
 - ☐ Nobody can say whether buying out is a right, a concession, or a habit.
 - ☐ The work still gets done, and resentment about it has stopped being expressed.
- 09 **Finances nobody can inspect** L3
- ☐ The accounts are available in principle and nobody has asked to see them in years.
 - ☐ Reporting is a headline figure rather than something anybody could check.
 - ☐ One or two people know the full financial picture, and both are indispensable.
 - ☐ Questions about money get answered with reassurance rather than numbers.
- 10 **The commons sold to cover the shortfall** L3
- ☐ An operating shortfall has been closed by a sale more than once.
 - ☐ Nobody can say how many saleable assets are left.
 - ☐ The agreements say nothing about which resources may not be sold.
 - ☐ A sale is described as releasing a non-core asset, and nobody defines core.

WHO BELONGS, AND WHO DECIDES THAT

- 11 **Removal with no process** L1
- ☐ The agreements state no grounds for removal, or state them without a process.
 - ☐ A removal is under discussion and the procedure is being written alongside it.
 - ☐ Nobody can say what the person could have done to avoid it, or could do to return.
 - ☐ The decision is being made by the people the difficulty is with.
- 12 **Rules that spread into private life** L0
- ☐ The community has an agreed position on something it does not own or maintain.
 - ☐ Nobody can say what is definitively nobody else's business.
 - ☐ Members ask permission for things that were never anyone's to grant.
 - ☐ People stop mentioning parts of their life rather than argue about them.
- 13 **The norm nobody could enforce** L0
- ☐ A value is central to how the community describes itself and appears in no agreement.
 - ☐ Nobody can say what would happen if somebody simply declined to observe it.
 - ☐ The question is being discussed everywhere except the meeting.
 - ☐ Members disagree, sincerely, about whether it was ever a rule or only a shared habit.
- 14 **The purpose that quietly changed** L0
- ☐ Longer-standing and newer members describe what the place is for in different words.
 - ☐ Proposals get argued as practical questions that are really about direction.
 - ☐ The founding vision is quoted mainly by people losing an argument.
 - ☐ Nobody can say when the purpose last changed, or whether it did.

THE WORK THAT BREAKS PEOPLE

- 15 **Care work nobody counts** L5
- ☐ The rota covers physical tasks and nothing else, and everyone knows other work exists.
 - ☐ The same people follow up after difficult meetings, and it is not anybody's role.
 - ☐ Somebody is described as good at people, and that is the whole arrangement.
 - ☐ A member's departure would leave a gap nobody could name in advance.
- 16 **Growth that outpaces onboarding** L5
- ☐ Onboarding is a person being generous with their time rather than a process.
 - ☐ Recent joiners describe the agreements differently from long-standing members.
 - ☐ The same questions get answered from scratch for every arrival.
 - ☐ Nobody can say what a new member is supposed to have read.
- 17 **Information nobody can reach** L5
- ☐ Answering an ordinary question requires asking a specific person.
 - ☐ Nobody can say where decisions from four years ago are recorded, or whether they are.
 - ☐ Access to accounts, keys or systems has never been written down as a list.
 - ☐ New members take a long time to become useful, and nobody knows why.

- 18 **Responsibility that becomes authority** L5
- ☐ Decisions in an area are made by whoever handles that area, without anybody deciding they should be.
 - ☐ Members say one person has too much, and have said so for a long time.
 - ☐ Nobody could take a task over without a substantial handover that has never been written.
 - ☐ The overloaded person would like help and cannot say what help would look like.
- 19 **Self-sufficiency without contribution** L5
- ☐ Attendance at shared work and shared meals has fallen without any decision being made.
 - ☐ Some households are effectively neighbours who share a driveway, and nobody has said so.
 - ☐ The people who still turn up are increasingly the same people.
 - ☐ Non-participation has never been raised with anybody, because nobody wants to be the one.
- CHANGES THAT CANNOT BE UNDONE
- 20 **A community that forgot why** L6
- ☐ A rule is followed and nobody present can say what it was for.
 - ☐ Two versions of a document exist and nobody can say which one is in force.
 - ☐ Decisions are recorded as outcomes, without who decided them or under what rule.
 - ☐ The people who could explain the history are the people who left.
- 21 **Experiments with no way back** L6
- ☐ Something introduced as a trial is still running, and nobody set a review date.
 - ☐ Nobody can say what would have counted as the experiment failing.
 - ☐ Reverting would now cost more than the change did, and that argument is winning.
 - ☐ Members disagree about whether it was ever agreed permanently.
- 22 **Governance with no path to change it** L6
- ☐ Nothing significant has been amended in years, and nobody experiences this as stability.
 - ☐ Attempts to change something die in procedure rather than on the merits.
 - ☐ Members describe proposals as not worth the effort, and are right.
 - ☐ The amendment rule requires a level of agreement the community can no longer reach.
- 23 **Sub-groups with undefined autonomy** L6
- ☐ Sub-groups have formed and no document says what they may decide alone.
 - ☐ Two parts of the community have different rules on the same question, discovered by accident.
 - ☐ Nobody can say whether the main agreements bind a sub-group, or how one could differ.
 - ☐ A decision made in one part turns out to commit the whole community.
- 24 **The emergency measure that stayed** L6
- ☐ An arrangement adopted during something urgent is still running, and nobody set an end date.
 - ☐ Precedent is doing the work that a written rule should be doing – we did it last time.
 - ☐ Nobody can say what would count as the emergency being over.
 - ☐ The people who acted quickly were right, and that is why nobody wants to revisit it.

- ☐ The community has principles it calls non-negotiable and no rule saying how they change.
- ☐ The same process amends the guest policy and the constitution.
- ☐ Members would be shocked by a change that is procedurally available today.
- ☐ Nobody can list what could never be decided by a simple majority.

From the Ultimate Guide to Why Communities Fail, as it stood on 13 August 2026. Each pattern has its own page – what it looks like from inside, why it is hard to see, and what to change – free at ecohubs.community/learn/guides/why-communities-fail.

Print it, copy it, translate it. If you ticked something this sheet has no line for, we would like to know.